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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump dogged by Epstein furor

Disgraced financier’s imprisoned accomplice meets with Department of Justice officials for second day

By **Chris Megerian and Eric Tucker**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Despite the sun bearing down on him and the sweat beading across his face, President Donald Trump still lingered with reporters lined up outside the White House on Friday. He was leaving on a trip to Scotland, where he would visit his golf

courses, and he wanted to talk about how his administration just finished “the best six months ever.”

But over and over, the journalists kept asking Trump about the Jeffrey Epstein case and whether he would pardon the disgraced financier’s imprisoned accomplice and former girlfriend, Ghislaine Maxwell.

“People should really focus on how well the country is doing,” Trump insisted. He

shut down another question by saying, “I don’t want to talk about that.”

It was another example of how the Epstein saga — and his administration’s disjointed approach to it — has shadowed Trump when he’s otherwise at the height of his influence.

He’s enacted a vast legislative agenda, announced the frameworks of trade deals with key countries and tightened his grip across the federal government.

Yet he’s struggled to stamp out the embers of a political crisis that could become a full-on conflagration.

The Republican president’s supporters want the government to release secret files about Epstein, who authorities say killed himself in his New York jail cell six years ago while awaiting trial for sex trafficking.

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CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

BEST SPUDS

Alicia Saucedo, left, and Selena Sanchez participate in the potato dance as the American Indian Center hosts a community powwow at Harrison Park in Chicago’s Pilsen neighborhood on Thursday. The program was part of the Chicago Park District’s Night Out in the Parks series. Potato dancing is a staple at powwows across the land, often presented as a competition in which pairs attempt to move together to the beat without dropping a tuber placed snugly between their foreheads.

At Rush, a new test to help detect cancers

Some health systems wary of screening not OK’d by FDA

By **Lisa Schencker**
Chicago Tribune

Jack Welter didn’t feel sick when he agreed to take a new blood test that looks for multiple types of cancer. But, approaching 60, he thought it couldn’t hurt.

To his surprise, the test came back positive. Welter then underwent multiple rounds of follow-up tests, and ultimately, doctors found cancer in his throat.

The now 61-year-old Elkhart, Indiana, resident endured radiation and chemother-

apy in 2023 and is now cancer-free.

“Without that test, I still would have had (cancer), obviously, but it might not have appeared for another year or more,” said Welter, who is expecting his first grandchild. “Early detection is the key to success.”

In recent years, the blood test, called Galleri, and others like it, have been gaining momentum among doctors who use them to help detect cancers that otherwise might go unnoticed until patients become ill. Now, at least one local health system, Rush University System for Health, has decided to start offering Galleri to patients widely in hopes of finding cancer early, when it’s easier to treat.

The test has not yet been approved by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration and is not covered by most health insurance plans. At Rush, it will cost most people \$749 out-of-pocket. Providers at other local health systems have expressed wariness about offering the test broadly at this point, given those concerns and others.

But Rush leaders felt it was important to move forward with the test, given its potential life-changing benefits for patients and because of its performance in clinical trials, said Dr. Lisa Stempel, director of the high-risk cancer screening program at Rush.

“The goal of all screening is to find

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Mayor vows no push for property tax hike in 2026

CFO called increase ‘likely’ earlier this week in attempt to eat away at budget hole

By **Jake Sheridan**
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson is now ruling out seeking a property tax hike in his upcoming budget proposal, an apparent change in course for his administration after a top city official said earlier in the week that they probably would do so.

On Friday, Johnson said he will instead try again to tax the city’s wealthiest residents and corporations. He added that he has “a number” of ideas for progressive revenue, but did not answer when asked to share them.

“The ultra-rich in this city and this state have an opportunity to do a better job in investing in our infrastructure, investing in community safety,” he said.

Johnson told the Tribune that “nothing has changed” when asked about the apparent abrupt switch-up during a news conference.

The mayor’s attempts to raise property taxes to balance this year’s budget were roundly rejected by aldermen. But he said he isn’t turning away from property taxes to close the 2026 budget hole because he’s worried he doesn’t have the votes.

“We’ve always made it very clear from

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INSIDE Another rough day for Bears’ offense

C Intercepted on consecutive plays during seven-on-seven drills, quarterback Caleb Williams had a tough go of it during the Bears’ third practice of training camp — the first in front of fans — on Friday in Lake Forest. **Chicago Sports**

■ Judge dismisses Trump administration lawsuit over sanctuary policies in Illinois and Chicago. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

Chicago communities rebounding from stain of hateful defacements

By **William Tong**
Chicago Tribune

Daniel Kirzane said he was cautious and curious after learning someone posted antisemitic graffiti across the street from his synagogue in Hyde Park. While the congregation contacted Chicago police just to be safe, Kirzane said he didn’t think it was a “real threat.”

Rather, Kirzane said he viewed it as “public intimidation” — the kind his congregation wouldn’t “give in to.”

“These aren’t the values we hold by in Hyde Park, which is a community that’s proud of its diversity,” said Kirzane, rabbi

at KAM Isaiah Israel Congregation. “And I think many Jews are upset to be singled out in this negative way.”

Vandals tagged at least four locations in Hyde Park in June with antisemitic messages, police said. Murals depicting solidarity with Palestinians and immigrants were defaced that same month in Pilsen. Just weeks later, taggers drew hate symbols and language on buildings in Little Village. The rash of vandalism has shaken communities across Chicago, and while residents have mustered support for their affected neighbors, the vandalism reflects

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Owners Bibiana Mesa, right, and her husband, Juan Ocampo, paint over graffiti reading “ICE RULES” on Sunday after a vandal tagged their grocery store, La Fruteria, for the second night in a row in the 2700 block of West Cermak Avenue in the Little Village neighborhood of Chicago. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

